

OPEN ARMS CONSULTING

MoneyMike Content Property for Zara Law Firm

Build Guide & Build-vs-Rent Analysis

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Confidential — prepared exclusively for Zara Law Firm's internal planning use.

Executive Summary

Zara has already done the slow part: the MoneyMike social accounts exist on every target platform, and management-level access to run them is already connected. That single fact changes this decision. Normally the first 1-3 weeks of a project like this are consumed by account creation, business verification, and getting the right people admin access — Zara is starting past that line.

The headline numbers (Tier 2 scale: 2-3 users, ~10 profiles, the realistic scale for a firm with multiple attorneys posting):

Path	Timeline to live	Year 1 cost	3-year cost
Build (MoneyMike property, "PostPilot pattern")	3-5 weeks part-time	~\$10,900 - \$21,000	~\$12,700 - \$27,000
Rent — cheapest (Buffer, Team plan)	Days	\$1,200	\$3,600
Rent — most expensive (Sprout Social, Professional)	Days	\$10,764	\$32,292

Buffer is genuinely, honestly cheaper than building — that needs to be said plainly, not buried. But Buffer is also the shallowest option: no compliance-oriented approval workflow, no audit trail built for a regulated industry, and no way to encode a MoneyMike persona voice or an attorney-sign-off-before-publish rule the way this firm needs it. Sprout Social has the strongest out-of-box compliance story of the three vendors but costs more over three years than building the property outright, and Sprout's own customers report real friction getting out of contracts. Building lands in the middle of the rental price range in raw dollars — and at the end of it, Zara owns the thing instead of leasing it indefinitely.

Three takeaways a board member can absorb in 60 seconds:

1. **The expensive part is already done.** Accounts and platform integrations exist — the remaining build is measured in weeks, not months, and in low five figures, not six. 2. **"Cheap SaaS" and "compliance-grade SaaS" are two different products at two very different prices.** Buffer is cheap but thin; Sprout Social is compliance-postured but costs more over three years than owning the asset outright, with documented cancellation friction in customer reviews. 3. **No vendor sells a MoneyMike-voiced, attorney-approval-gated posting workflow off the shelf.** That customization — the part that actually matters for a law firm's advertising-rule exposure — is only available by building it.

PART A — Build Guide: The PostPilot Pattern

This is the step-by-step plan for building the MoneyMike property using the same technical pattern Jonathan used to build PostPilot, his prior in-house social auto-poster and analytics tool: a TypeScript full-stack application (Next.js-style), deployed on Vercel, using the Anthropic Claude API for AI-assisted content generation, built on a minimum-viable-infrastructure philosophy — no more moving parts than the job requires. The specifics below describe the pattern and its build steps, not a direct copy of PostPilot's code; MoneyMike will be its own build, following the same proven approach.

Total timeline and cost (estimate)

	Estimate
Build effort	~20-29 person-days
Calendar timeline	3-5 weeks, part-time
One-time build cost	\$10,000 - \$18,000
Ongoing monthly running cost	\$75 - \$250/mo (Vercel hosting + Claude API usage, scales with posting volume)

These are estimates based on the scope of work below and standard technical-consulting rates for this class of build — clearly labeled as estimates, not a fixed quote. Final scope and price would be confirmed in a statement of work.

Phase 1 — Foundations Already in Place

Effort: 0 days (already complete) | What Zara sees: confirmation of what's already usable

Zara already has the MoneyMike brand's social accounts created across the relevant platforms, and management-level access to those accounts (page/business-manager admin rights, not just a personal login) is already connected. In a typical build, this step alone — account creation, business verification, and getting the right people the correct admin roles on each platform — routinely eats 1-3 weeks before any code gets written. That time is already saved here. This phase is listed for completeness and so the timeline below is understood in context: it starts from Phase 2, not from zero.

Phase 2 — Platform API Access & OAuth Setup

Effort: 3-5 days | What Zara sees: a working, authenticated connection from the app to every platform, ready to post and read data

- Register the MoneyMike application with each platform's developer program: Meta (for Facebook and Instagram, via the Graph API), LinkedIn, TikTok (Content Posting API), and YouTube (Data API).
- Complete each platform's app-review process where required. Meta in particular requires review before an app can publish to Pages/Instagram business accounts on behalf of a business — this is a real step, not a formality, and can add lead time outside the developer's direct control. Because Zara's accounts and admin access already exist, this step is narrower than a from-scratch build (no business verification needed), but review timing itself is still gated by the platform, not by us.
- Build secure OAuth token storage with automatic refresh, so long-lived access doesn't silently expire and interrupt posting.
- Put law-firm-appropriate account-safety practices in place: rate-limit posting to stay well under each platform's automation thresholds, avoid patterns that read as spam/bot behavior to platform trust-and-safety systems, and keep a clear audit trail of what the app posted and when — protecting the firm's existing accounts from being flagged or restricted.

Phase 3 — Content Pipeline (Claude-Assisted, Attorney-Gated)

Effort: 5-7 days | What Zara sees: a draft-generation and review queue where MoneyMike content is written, but nothing goes out until a named attorney approves it

- Build a content-generation workflow using the Anthropic Claude API, with a style/persona guide encoded into the system prompt so drafts consistently sound like "MoneyMike" rather than generic AI copy.
- Build a drafting queue: content is generated on a schedule or on demand, then lands in a "pending review" state — it does not publish automatically.
- **Build a mandatory attorney-approval step before anything posts.** This is non-negotiable for a law firm: state bar advertising and solicitation rules vary by jurisdiction and commonly require attorney review of

public-facing marketing content, along with recordkeeping of what was approved and by whom. (This document intentionally does not cite specific bar rules — Zara's own counsel should confirm the applicable rules for each jurisdiction the firm practices in; the workflow is built to accommodate that review, not to substitute for it.) - Every approval, edit, and rejection is logged with a timestamp and the approving attorney's identity, creating a simple, defensible record of the firm's review process — useful both for compliance and for continuity if a question ever comes up about a specific post.

Phase 4 — Scheduler / Auto-Poster

Effort: 4-6 days | What Zara sees: a posting calendar where approved content goes out automatically, on schedule, across all connected platforms

- Build the scheduling engine on Vercel's cron infrastructure, triggering publish jobs at set times.
- Build per-platform "publish adapters" — one integration per platform (Meta Graph API, LinkedIn API, TikTok Content Posting API, YouTube Data API) so a single approved piece of content can be routed to the right platform in the right format.
- Add retry logic with backoff for transient failures (a platform API hiccup shouldn't mean a missed post), and failure alerting so a human is notified immediately if something can't be posted — nothing fails silently.
- Build a simple posting-calendar view so the team can see what's queued for the week at a glance.

Phase 5 — Analytics

Effort: 5-7 days | What Zara sees: one dashboard showing how MoneyMike content is performing across every platform, plus a weekly summary in their inbox

- Build per-platform metrics ingestion (impressions, engagement, follower growth, video views, etc.) pulled on a schedule from each platform's own analytics/insights API.
- Normalize and store that data centrally so metrics from different platforms can be compared on one timeline instead of five separate vendor dashboards.
- Build a unified analytics dashboard inside the MoneyMike app itself.
- Build an automated weekly digest (email) summarizing performance for firm leadership — no login required to stay informed.

Phase 6 — Launch, QA & Handoff

Effort: 3-4 days | What Zara sees: a supervised first week of live posting, then a documented handoff

- Run the system in dry-run mode first — generating and queuing content, simulating posts, but not actually publishing — to confirm the pipeline works end to end before anything goes live.
- Go live with a first supervised week: Jonathan actively monitors posting, approval flow, and analytics ingestion in real time and fixes anything that surfaces.
- Deliver a written runbook: how to add a new platform later, how to rotate an expiring token, what to do if a post fails, and who to contact if something breaks.
- Short handoff/training session with whoever at Zara will manage day-to-day approvals.

PART B — Rent vs. Build

Table 1: Vendor Pricing Comparison

All figures are **estimates researched via secondary sources** (vendor pricing pages could not be directly fetched during this research pass — see *Sources & Caveats* below). Figures assume annual billing, which was cheaper than month-to-month for all three vendors in every source consulted.

Tier 1 — 1 user, ~5 profiles

Vendor	Plan	Monthly	1-year	3-year	Notes
Buffer	Essentials, 5 channels	\$25	\$300	\$900	Cheapest at this tier. Per-channel pricing.
Hootsuite	Professional, 1 user	\$99	\$1,188	\$3,564	Better-corroborated of two conflicting pricing structures found — see caveats.
Sprout Social	Standard, 1 seat	\$199	\$2,388	\$7,164	Exactly meets 5-profile cap; no headroom without add-on fees.

Tier 2 — 2-3 users, ~10 profiles

Vendor	Plan	Monthly	1-year	3-year	Notes
Buffer	Team, 10 channels	\$100	\$1,200	\$3,600	Cheapest at this tier. No per-seat fee, scales with channel count.
Hootsuite	Team, 3 users (flat)	\$249	\$2,988	\$8,964	Unverified structure — could be as high as ~\$597/mo (\$7,164/yr) under an alternate per-user pricing scheme found in some sources. See caveats.
Sprout Social	Professional, 3 seats	\$897	\$10,764	\$32,292	Most expensive at this tier — strict per-seat pricing. Strongest compliance/approval-workflow feature set of the three.

Table 2: Rent vs. Build — Side by Side

Dimension	Rent (SaaS)	Build (MoneyMike property)
3-year total cost (Tier 2 scale)	\$3,600 (Buffer) to \$32,292 (Sprout Social)	~\$12,700 - \$27,000 (one-time build + hosting/API)
Time to value	Days — sign up and connect accounts	~3-5 weeks part-time (shortened because accounts/integrations already exist)
Ownership of data & asset	Vendor platform holds the workflow and history; content data is exportable but the tool itself is rented, not owned	Zara owns the codebase, the content history, and the analytics data outright
Customization (MoneyMike persona, attorney approval)	Generic AI drafting tools and generic approval workflows, not tailored to a specific persona voice or a firm's specific review process	Purpose-built: MoneyMike's voice is encoded directly; the approval step is built around Zara's own review process
Compliance fit	Sprout Social markets compliance/audit-trail features explicitly for regulated industries, but which tier fully includes audit-log/record-retention functionality is unconfirmed in available sources; Buffer and Hootsuite have thinner compliance-specific stories	Built from the outset with a mandatory pre-publish attorney review step and a logged approval record, matched to this firm's actual process

Dimension	Rent (SaaS)	Build (MoneyMike property)
Switching / lock-in risk	Ordinary vendor risk: price increases (Hootsuite reportedly raised prices ~40% in 2025-2026 per multiple sources), contract/renewal friction (Sprout Social has multiple 2025-2026 reviews describing difficult cancellations and auto-renewal disputes)	No vendor lock-in on the SaaS side, but ongoing reliance on Open Arms Consulting (or an in-house developer) for maintenance — a different kind of dependency, not zero dependency
Ongoing fees	Recurring forever; Buffer and Sprout Social both scale cost with more users/channels as the firm grows	One-time build cost, then a comparatively flat, low monthly infrastructure cost that does not scale with headcount

Cost vs. opportunity

Judged purely on 3-year dollars, Buffer is the cheapest path in this comparison, full stop — that should not be spun away. Where building earns its cost back is in what gets bought along with it: an asset the firm owns outright rather than rents forever, a posting workflow built around this firm's actual attorney-review process rather than a generic approval feature, and a cost structure that does not grow every time the firm adds a user or a platform. A SaaS subscription is a recurring tax that grows with the firm; a built property is a fixed cost that, once paid, keeps producing without a growing bill attached. There is also a resale/reuse value to an owned asset that a SaaS subscription simply does not have — the codebase, content pipeline, and approval workflow are Zara's to keep, modify, or repurpose regardless of what any vendor does to its pricing next year.

Against Sprout Social specifically — the vendor with the most compliance-relevant feature set — building is not just competitive, it is cheaper over three years (\$12,700-\$27,000 built vs. \$32,292 rented), before accounting for Sprout's documented cancellation-friction complaints in customer reviews. Against Hootsuite, building costs somewhat more in the best-documented pricing scenario, but if Hootsuite's less-corroborated, higher per-user pricing structure turns out to be the one currently live, building would be cheaper there too. Against Buffer, building costs more — that gap buys the persona customization and compliance workflow Buffer does not offer, and reasonable people, including a skeptical board member, could disagree about whether that gap is worth paying for. That is a judgment call for Zara to make, not a foregone conclusion.

Time analysis

Rent is live this week. Build is live in about a month, but stays live — and stays Zara's — after that. Because Zara has already cleared the slowest part of a typical build (account creation and platform admin access), the usual gap between "rent now" and "own it in a couple months" is unusually narrow here: three to five weeks, not a full quarter. That narrows the practical case for renting-as-a-stopgap specifically for this project, though it does not eliminate it if immediate, uninterrupted posting cadence matters starting tomorrow.

Where SaaS honestly wins

This should not read as a sales pitch for building, so it is worth being direct about where renting wins on the merits: SaaS tools are live immediately, they are mature products with dedicated support teams, they get security and platform-API updates pushed automatically without Zara paying for developer time, and they carry none of the "what if the one person who understands this leaves" risk that comes with any custom-built internal tool. If Zara's priority is speed above all else, or if the firm wants zero ongoing technical dependency on a single outside developer, renting — specifically Buffer, the cheapest and least locked-in of the three — is a legitimate, defensible choice, not a lesser one.

Recommendation

Build the MoneyMike property, on the strength of three facts specific to Zara's situation: the account and integration groundwork is already done (removing the part of a typical build that costs the most time), the firm's advertising-rule review needs a genuinely custom attorney-approval workflow that no vendor sells off the shelf, and the 3-year cost of building sits at or below the compliance-oriented SaaS option (Sprout Social) while being paid once instead of forever.

Hybrid option, if immediate posting cadence matters: If Zara wants MoneyMike posting to continue without a gap during the 3-5 week build, start a Buffer Essentials or Team subscription month-to-month now (no contract, cancel anytime) to bridge the gap, and cancel it once the built property goes live. This costs roughly \$25-\$100/mo for the bridge period only and avoids committing to any vendor's annual contract for a capability being replaced within weeks.

Not recommended: Signing an annual or multi-year SaaS contract (particularly Sprout Social, given its documented cancellation friction) as a long-term solution, when the underlying need — a compliant, on-brand, owned MoneyMike property — is achievable in a comparable timeframe at a comparable or lower 3-year cost.

Sources & Caveats

Methodology note: Pricing research for this document was conducted via web search on 2026-08-04. Direct access to vendor pricing pages (hootsuite.com/plans, buffer.com/pricing, sproutsocial.com/pricing) was not available in the research session due to a network-level restriction, not a vendor-specific block. All pricing figures below are drawn from search-engine summaries of, and third-party aggregator/review sites quoting, those vendor pages, cross-checked across multiple independent sources where possible. **Recommend a direct check of each vendor's live pricing page before signing anything.**

Flagged for verification before contract signing

- **Hootsuite Tier 2 pricing is unresolved.** Sources conflict on Hootsuite's current plan structure. The better-corroborated version (Vendr, ContentStudio, NapoleonCat, TemperStack, CostBench, Ampifire) gives a flat \$249/mo Team plan (3 users, 20 profiles) used in this document. A second set of 2026-dated sources (SocialChamp, CreatorStackClub, ToolsBrief, NubiaPage, one G2 summary) describes a renamed, ~40% higher, possibly per-user pricing structure that would put 3 users at roughly \$597/mo (\$7,164/yr) instead. **Verify directly at hootsuite.com/plans before budgeting against the Hootsuite figures in this document.** - **Sprout Social Tier 2 alternate path unverified.** A cheaper Tier 2 configuration (Standard at 3 seats plus per-profile add-ons, ~\$722/mo) may exist as an alternative to the Professional plan used in this document (\$897/mo), but was not independently confirmed and Standard's approval-workflow depth may be inferior. Verify with Sprout Social directly. - **Sprout Social's audit-log/compliance-record tier gating is unconfirmed.** One source suggested full audit-trail/record-retention functionality may be Enterprise-tier only rather than included at Professional. If compliance recordkeeping is the deciding factor for choosing Sprout Social, confirm this before purchase. - **Buffer's volume-discount tiers** (channels 11-25, 26-50, 51+) were reported by aggregator sites but not independently confirmed on Buffer's own pricing page. - **All build-cost and timeline figures in Part A are Open Arms Consulting estimates**, based on the scope of work described and standard rates for this class of technical build. They are not vendor quotes and should be treated as planning ranges pending a final statement of work.

Source URLs (accessed via web search 2026-08-04)

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